FX Exposure, Treatment Effects, and Support for Government Intervention: Evidence from Poland

Option B Reference Paper

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1 Data

We use survey data from the October 2015 wave of the Polish CBOS public opinion survey, which included an embedded experiment on attitudes toward government intervention in the Swiss franc mortgage market. The sample consists of 2,044 Polish adults, recruited to be nationally representative through stratified random sampling. Respondents were asked about their support for government intervention to help households with Swiss franc–denominated mortgages, a politically salient question following the Swiss National Bank's (SNB) removal of its CHF/EUR exchange rate floor in January 2015.

Figure 1 shows the CHF/PLN exchange rate over the period surrounding the SNB's policy change. The vertical dashed line marks January 15, 2015, when the SNB unexpectedly removed the floor on the CHF/EUR exchange rate. This event caused an immediate and large appreciation of the Swiss franc against both the euro and the Polish zloty, sharply increasing monthly repayments for Polish households holding CHF-denominated mortgages.

Respondents were randomly assigned to one of four conditions: a control condition (`cntrl`), an information treatment describing the financial consequences of FX loans (`info`), a history treatment providing context about past currency shocks (`history`), and a Hungary treatment referencing the Hungarian government's intervention on behalf of FX borrowers (`Hungary`). The outcome of interest is a binary indicator for whether the respondent supports government intervention. In addition to treatment assignment and outcome, we observe each respondent's FX exposure status (none, current loan, or past loan), age, gender, education level, urban–rural residence, household income quintile, left–right ideological self-placement, and survey weight.

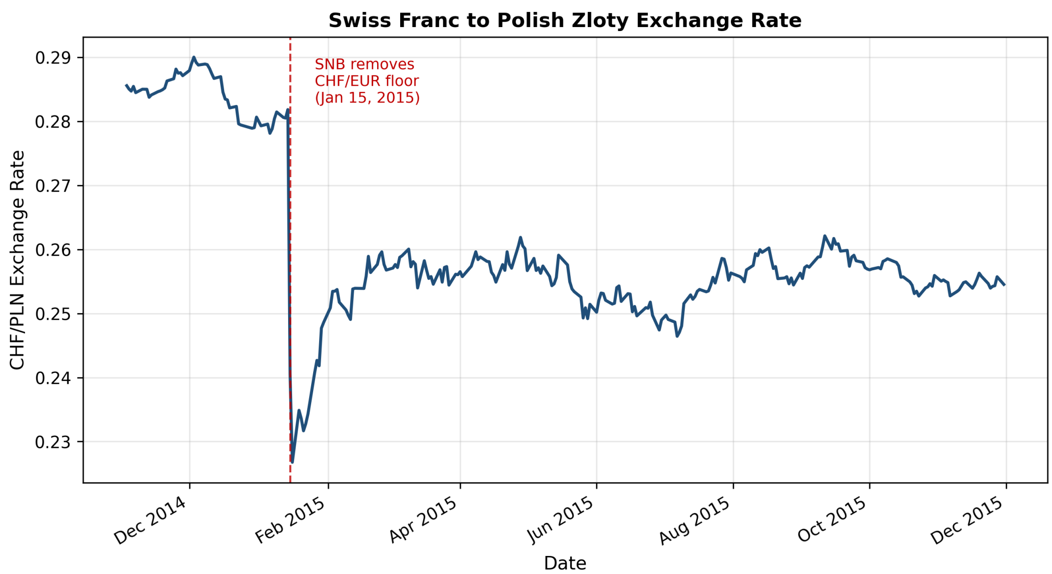

Figure 1: Swiss franc to Polish zloty exchange rate, 2014–2015. The dashed red line marks the SNB's removal of the CHF/EUR floor on January 15, 2015.

2 Results

2.1 Sample Characteristics

Table 1 reports summary statistics for the key variables in our analysis sample. Roughly half of respondents support government intervention in the FX mortgage market, consistent with the politically contested nature of the issue. The sample is balanced on gender and spans the full range of observed education, income, and ideological positioning. A small but meaningful share of respondents report current or past Swiss franc–denominated loan exposure, providing the variation needed to identify differential treatment responses among exposed and unexposed respondents.

2.2 Main Results

Table 2 presents our main results. Column (1) reports a baseline logistic regression of support for intervention on treatment assignment only, weighted by the survey sampling weights. Column (2) adds demographic controls (age, gender, education, urban–rural residence) and controls for FX exposure status.

The information treatment produces a significant increase in support for government intervention relative to the control group, with a coefficient of approximately 0.3 log-odds in both specifications. Providing historical context (the history treatment) or information about the Hungarian intervention (the Hungary treatment) produces smaller and statistically

Table 1: Summary Statistics

Variable	N	Mean	SD	Min	Max
Supports intervention (0/1)	2036	0.48	0.50	0.00	1.00
Age (years)	2044	48.81	17.58	18.00	85.00
Female (0/1)	2044	0.54	0.50	0.00	1.00
Education level (1–5)	2044	2.52	1.07	1.00	4.00
Urban–rural (1–5)	2044	1.85	0.80	1.00	3.00
Income quintile (1–5)	1479	3.13	1.45	0.00	5.00
Left–right placement (0–10)	1502	0.47	1.56	-3.00	3.00
FX exposed, current (0/1)	2044	0.03	0.18	0.00	1.00
FX exposed, past (0/1)	2044	0.03	0.16	0.00	1.00

insignificant effects, suggesting that information about direct financial consequences is the primary mechanism driving attitude change. Having a current FX loan is strongly associated with supporting intervention, a result that is robust across specifications.

Table 2: Main Results: Effect of Treatment on Support for Intervention

	(1) *Baseline*	(2) *+ Controls*
Info treatment	0.302^{**}	0.324^{**}
	(0.126)	(0.127)
History treatment	0.123	0.133
	(0.128)	(0.130)
Hungary treatment	0.194	0.185
	(0.130)	(0.131)
FX exposed (current)		1.287^{***}
		(0.283)
FX exposed (past)		-0.163
		(0.289)
Demographic controls	No	Yes
Survey weights	Yes	Yes
N	2036	2035

$^{***}p < 0.01$; $^{**}p < 0.05$; $^{*}p < 0.1$.

2.3 Robustness

Table 3 reports a battery of robustness checks. Specifications (1) and (2) compare weighted and unweighted estimates, showing that the information treatment effect is not driven by the choice of weighting. Specifications (3) and (4) add progressively richer sets of control variables, including household income and political ideology. The information treatment effect attenuates modestly but remains positive as controls are added; notably, the sample size drops sharply in column (4) due to item nonresponse in the income and ideology measures, illustrating a missing-data trap that shrinks statistical power.

Specification (5) pools all three information-bearing treatments into a single *any information* indicator, which is positive and significant, consistent with the column (1)–(3) results. Specification (6) restricts the sample to urban respondents and recovers a treatment effect similar in magnitude to the full-sample estimate. Taken together, the robustness checks confirm that the information treatment increases support for government intervention, while the other treatments show no consistent effect.

Table 3: Logistic Regression: Support for Government Intervention

	(1) Base (weighted)	(2) Base (unweighted)	(3) + Controls	(4) Full controls	(5) Pooled treatment	(6) Urban only
Info treatment	0.302^{**}	0.290^{**}	0.324^{**}	0.267		0.326^{*}
	(0.126)	(0.126)	(0.127)	(0.170)		(0.167)
History treatment	0.123	0.047	0.133	0.261		0.242
	(0.128)	(0.127)	(0.130)	(0.174)		(0.169)
Hungary treatment	0.194	0.145	0.185	0.225		0.221
	(0.130)	(0.129)	(0.131)	(0.176)		(0.169)
Any information					0.218^{**}	
					(0.107)	
FX exposed (current)			1.287^{***}	1.251^{***}	1.290^{***}	1.256^{***}
			(0.283)	(0.352)	(0.283)	(0.319)
FX exposed (past)			−0.163	−0.168	−0.158	−0.049
			(0.289)	(0.356)	(0.289)	(0.331)
Demographic controls	No	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Survey weights	Yes	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Sample	Full	Full	Full	Full	Full	Urban
N	2036	2036	2035	1151	2035	1208

$^{***}p < 0.01$; $^{**}p < 0.05$; $^{*}p < 0.1$. Reference: control group, no FX loan.